

Jung and Tarot: A theory-practice nexus in education and counselling

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Since Aristotle, the relationship between theory and practice has been controversial. Theory is derived from *theoria*—defined as a philosophical contemplation of higher truths and as such disengaged from practical, political contexts and social life; that is from *praxis*, which is defined as the process of putting theoretical knowledge into practice and is embedded in actions, relationships and experiences that by definition have an ethical or moral dimension. The research presented here represents a theory-practice nexus. It originated long ago as the action-project representing a type of research analogous to what Jungian scholar Robert Romanyshyn will have called years later *research with soul in mind* (Romanyshyn, 2007). Referring to the *Imaginal*, Romanyshyn emphasised the role of this third dimension between the senses and the intellect as enabling an embodied way of being in the world within the context of complex mind reaching into the whole of nature. It was philosopher Henry Corbin who coined the *Imaginal world*—*Mundus Imaginalis* or *mundus archetypus*, the archetypal world—as a distinct order of reality corresponding to a *distinct mode of perception* in contrast to purely *imaginary* as the unreal or simply utopian. The archetypal world comprises what Carl Jung posited as the collective unconscious or *objective* psyche that manifests itself through symbols and images and is shared at a deeper, *psychoid*, level by all members of human-kind (Jung, 1959) thereby transcending cultural, temporal or language barriers.

The symbolic meanings of human experiences are ‘always grounded in the unconscious archetype, but their manifest forms are moulded by the ideas acquired by the conscious mind. The archetypes [as] structural elements of the psyche ... possess a certain autonomy and specific energy which enables them to attract, out of the conscious mind, those contents which are better suited to themselves’ (Jung CW 5. 232) thus helping in achieving much wider scope of awareness than rational thinking, in terms of solely cognitive reasoning—deprived of what Jung called feeling-tone—is capable of providing. The integration of the unconscious into consciousness contributes to the practical manifestation of the ultimate Jungian archetype of wholeness called the Self. For Jung, the profound relationship between the soul of the world, *Anima Mundi*, and an individual human consciousness remained a great mystery. He did not distinguish between the *psyche* and the material world: they represent two different aspects of the *Unus Mundus*, or one world. Archetype is seen by Jung as a skeletal pattern, filled in with imagery and motifs that are ‘mediated to us by the unconscious’ (CW 8. 417), the variable contents of which form different archetypal *images*. The archetypal images are the vehicles for/of information embedded in the collective unconscious, and the uncon-

scious is capable of spontaneously producing images 'irrespective of wishes and fears of the conscious mind' (Jung CW 11. 745). The archetypal images are 'endowed with a generative power; [the image] is psychically compelling' (Samuels *et al.*, 1986, 73). Contemporary post-Jungians consider the archetypes to be both the structuring patterns of the psyche and the dynamical units of information implicit in the contents of the collective unconscious. Archetypal psychologist James Hillman called for the rescue of images which are capable of 'releasing startling new insights' (Hillman, 1989, 25), and Jung pointed out that a 'symbolic process is an experience *in images and of images*' (Jung CW 9i, 82; italics in original).

A specific subject matter of my research is the set of images comprising a Tarot deck (e.g. Semetsky, 2006a, 2009, 2011) and representing in the symbolic form the very archetypes 'inhabiting' the Imaginal world. It is our cognitive function enriched with creative imagination that provides access to the Imaginal world with a rigor of knowledge specified since antiquity as knowing by analogy. The method of analogy defies the privileged role allotted to the self-conscious subject that observes the surrounding world of objects—from which the epistemic subject is forever detached—with the cool 'scientific' gaze of an independent spectator so as to obtain a certain and indubitable knowledge, or *episteme*. Rather, the method of analogy presupposes *participation*—contrary to observation—in the process of subjects and objects together forming a relational network as an interdependent holistic fabric with the world, thus overcoming the dualistic split that has been haunting us since the time of Descartes and is still confining us to what Corbin used to call the banal dualism of matter versus spirit. This relational approach agrees with Nel Noddings' ethics of care as a feminine alternative to the traditional model of character education (Noddings, 1984). Noddings points to such common global human experiences as birth, marriage, motherhood, death or separation, even while denying moral universals as predestined rules for our actions. These experiential events are fundamental; thus, they can be considered to have universal meanings for humankind, even when they are happening in different places across the globe, geographically, or in different periods in history. These common human experiences are symbolically represented by the images in Tarot pictures.

A typical Tarot layout comprises a particular pattern with each position having some specific connotations that become clear when an experienced reader creates an imaginative narrative out of the pictorial story. Non-incidentally, *imaginative narrative* is one of the methodologies employed by the innovative interdisciplinary field called *Futures Studies*, which also uses utopian thinking, forecasting and strategic planning. M. Peters and J. Freeman-Moir (2006) dedicate their recent volume, *Edutopias: New utopian thinking in education*, to future generations of educators capable of understanding that, with *imagination*, education can indeed transform individuals, raise collective consciousness and contribute to the development of global civic society. In this respect, Tarot represents an example of post-formal (Steinberg *et al.*, 1999) education grounded in an existing *cultural practice*—called, in popular parlance, Tarot readings—during which the pictorial 'language' of the unconscious is converted into verbal expressions, thereby facilitating the 'widening and deepening of conscious life [as] a more intense, disciplined, and expanding realisation of meanings ... And education is not a mere means to such a life. Education is such a life' (Dewey, 1916/1924, p. 417).

The word education derives from the Latin *educare*—to lead out as well as to bring out something that is within. The word therapy derives from the Greek *therapeia*, in terms of human service to those who need it. Education and counselling alike involve either implicit or explicit inquiry into the nature of the self and self-other relations. Carol Witherell notices that, ideally, each professional activity ‘furthers another’s capacity to find meaning and integrity’ (1991, p. 84) in lived experience. Importantly both practices are ‘designed to change or guide human lives’ (Witherell, 1991, 84). This was the focus of my research: to investigate a potential of Tarot as a transformative, at once educational and counselling, tool informed by a Jungian conceptual framework. For Jung, archetype is a symbol of transformation, and symbols—like those represented by the Tarot imagery—function as transformers capable of raising the unconscious contents to the level of consciousness: the implicit meanings become explicit by virtue of ‘becoming conscious and by being perceived’ (Jung in Pauli, 1994, 159). †

Jung’s biographer Laurens van der Post, in his introduction to the book *Jung and Tarot: an Archetypal Journey* by Sallie Nichols’ (herself Jung’s student in Zurich), notices the contribution made by Nichols to the profound investigation of Tarot, and her ‘illuminated exegesis of its pattern as an authentic attempt at enlargement of possibilities of human perceptions’ (in Nichols, 1980, xv). Andrew Samuels mentions ‘systems such as that of the *I Ching*, Tarot and astrology’ (1985, p. 123) as possible, even if uncertain, resources in analytical psychology and quotes Jung writing: ‘I found the *I Ching* very interesting. ... I have not used it for more than two years now, feeling that one must learn to walk in the dark, or try to discover (as when one is learning to swim) whether the water will carry one’ (in Samuels, 1985, 123). Irene Gad (1994) has connected Tarot pictures with the process of human development—what Jung called individuation—and considered their archetypal images to be ‘trigger symbols, appearing and disappearing throughout history in times of transition and need’ (p. xxxiv).

Tarot pictures are called Arcana, and the meaning of the word Arcana derives from Latin *arca* as a chest; the verb *arcere* means to shut or to close; symbolically, Arcanum (singular) is a tightly shut treasure chest holding a secret, its deep meaning. Nearly every one of the 78 Arcana in a deck—22 Major and 56 Minor—has an image of a living being, a human figure situated in different contexts. This figure is not just a physical body but the mind, soul and spirit as well. And while a body goes through life and accomplishes different tasks, the psyche goes through transformations, as human experience itself calls for the constant renewal and enlargement of our consciousness. The journey through Tarot imagery is at once learning and therapeutic as each new life experience contributes to self-understanding and self-knowledge. Noddings (2006) emphasises the importance of self-knowledge as the very core of education: ‘when we claim to *educate*, we must take Socrates seriously. Unexamined lives may well be valuable and worth living, but an education that does not invite such examination may not be worthy of the label *education*’ (Noddings, 2006, 10, italics in original). When symbolically represented in Tarot images, human experiences become reflected upon; thus indeed *examined*. The archetypal realm is brought, so to speak, *down to earth* by virtue of its *embodiment* in physical reality, confirming Jung’s insight that ‘psyche and matter are two different aspects of one and the same thing’ (Jung CW 8. 418). The apparent binary opposites are united in the process of reading and interpretation, thus defying Cartesian dualism both in theory and,

significantly, in practice! The levels of *praxis* as encompassing human behaviour, decision-making or choosing a particular course of action is of utmost significance. Jung insightfully commented that the general rules of human conduct are

at most provisional solutions, but never lead to those critical decisions which are the turning points in a man's life. As the author [Erich Neumann] rightly says: "The diversity and complexity of the situation makes it impossible for us to lay down any theoretical rules for ethical behaviour" ... The formulation of ethical rules is not only difficult but actually impossible because one can hardly think of a single rule that would not be reversed under certain conditions ... Through the new ethic, the ego-consciousness is ousted from its central position in a psyche organized on the lines of a monarchy or totalitarian state, its place being taken by *wholeness* or the *self*, which is now recognized as central" (Jung, 1949 in Neumann, 1969, p. 13; italics in original).

To achieve such wholeness, we have to evaluate real-life social situations as they arise in our very *practice* and learn the lessons embodied in the Tarot archetypal journey through what I call a symbolic school of life. Each and every Tarot reading as a mode of informal pedagogy becomes a step toward the conscious realisation of the deepest meaning (*corpus subtile*) of a particular situation; subsequently, an enlargement of consciousness itself becomes a step towards individuation. The true means of communication between the conscious mind and the unconscious is a language of symbols: 'symbols act as *transformers*, their function being to convert libido from a "lower" into a "higher" form' (Jung CW 5. 344). It is Tarot symbolism as a universal, even if 'silent' language (Semetsky, 2006b, 2010, forthcoming) that establishes such an unorthodox communicative link. The meanings of the symbols embedded in the pictures are not arbitrary but accord with a specific grammar of this universal language above and beyond verbal expressions of the conscious mind: 'it is not the personal human being who is making the statement, but the archetype speaking through him' (Jung, 1963, p. 352). In *Four Archetypes* Jung says: 'You need not be insane to hear his voice. On the contrary, it is the simplest and most natural thing imaginable ... [A] real colloquy becomes possible when the ego acknowledges the existence of a partner to the discussion' (CW 9. 236–237).

An expert reader transforms this implicit colloquy into an explicit dialogue when she functions as a 'bilingual' interpreter, converting the pictorial language of the unconscious into verbal expressions, thus facilitating the trans-formation of in-formation into consciousness. What takes place is an indirect, mediated, connection akin to the active principle of synchronicity posited by Jung in collaboration with the famous physicist and Nobel laureate Wolfgang Pauli. Synchronicity addresses the problematic of meaningful patterns generated both in nature and in human experience, linking the concept of the unconscious to the notion of "field" in physics [and extending] the old narrow idea of "causality" ... to a more general form of "connections" in nature' (Pauli, 1994, p.164). Pauli envisaged the development of theories of the unconscious as overgrowing their solely therapeutic applications by being eventually assimilated into *natural* sciences 'as applied to vital phenomena' (1994, p. 164). In his 1952 letter to Jung, Pauli expressed his belief in the gradual discovery of a new, what he called *neutral*, language that functions symbolically to describe the psychic reality of the archetypes and would be capable of

bridging the psycho-physical dualism. Jung described synchronicity not only in terms of a coincidence between mental content, or a dream, or a vision with the physical event, but also as a premonition about an event, ‘*a foreknowledge of some kind*’ (Jung CW 8. 931; italics in original). The reality of this implicit ‘self-subsistent “unconscious” knowledge’ (Jung CW 8. 931) of what we are meant to be and where we stand within the individuation process demonstrates itself *empirically* in the archetypal constellations of Tarot images during readings.

Archetypes ‘residing’ in the dynamic field of the collective unconscious form an unorthodox *virtual* foundation for moral knowledge upon which many individual real-life experiences lay down their own structures. Multiple combinations of innumerable experiences—the constellations of the actualised archetypes—produce diverse archetypal images that manifest overtly through their effects at the level of the body in the form of particular unconscious patterns of feelings and actions that are symbolically represented in the Tarot imagery. Archetypes do have two complementary poles, one expressing a ‘positive, favorable, bright side [and the other a] partly negative ... partly chthonic’ (Jung CW 9i. 413). It is ‘a natural process [as] a manifestation of [psychic] energy that springs from the tension of opposites’ (Jung CW 7. 121) expressed in the dark and light archetypal aspects, both pertaining to Tarot imagery not unlike *yin* and *yang* as an interplay of opposites in the Chinese Book of Changes. The difference between the opposites gives rise to the Jungian transcendent, unifying, function. By bringing to our awareness many initially unperceived and latent meanings, the unconscious contents of the archetypal images become *amplified* via their representation in the material medium of the pictures. Because of the amplifying, synthesising, nature of symbols, the meanings expressed in the multitude of images hiding in the unconscious can be elucidated, interpreted, narrated and potentially integrated into consciousness. The amplifying and synthetic character of symbols reflects the dynamical and evolutionary approach to knowledge and, for Jung, a ‘psychological fact ... as a living phenomenon ... is always indissolubly bound up with the continuity of the vital process, so that it is not only something evolved but also continually evolving and creative’ (Jung CW 6. 717) as a function of our lifelong learning from experience in the process of ‘Re-symbolization of the Self’ (Semetsky, 2011).

Many typical life experiences are represented in the patterns that appear and can be discerned when the pictures are being spread in this or that layout, and a person can learn from their experience when it is being unfolded in front of their eyes in the array of images. Respectively, the latent meanings of experience become available to human consciousness, and a person can discover in practice a deeper, spiritual or *numinous*, as Jung would say, dimension of experience. Thus Tarot, in terms of its archetypal dynamics, and despite being traditionally considered irrational and illogical, helps us achieve an intense scope of awareness exceeding narrow instrumental rationality. It is what educational psychologist Jerome Bruner called an intuitive sense of rightness that allows a genuine reader to articulate the implicit meanings of Tarot images and symbols. For Bruner, intuition ‘implies the act of grasping the meaning or significance or structure of a problem without explicit reliance on the analytic apparatus of one’s craft’ (Bruner, 1966, p.61). A symbolic, intuitive, approach creates a dialectical relationship between consciousness and the unconscious. In this respect, Tarot images may be viewed as a

bridge between the personal unconscious, via the archetypal field of the collective unconscious, to the conscious mind. Similar to the interpretations of dreams in Jungian analysis, Tarot hermeneutic (Semetsky, 2011) as reading and interpreting pictorial images becomes the core means of assisting people in the process of individuation. Etymologically, the Greek words *hermeneuein* and *hermeneia* for interpreting and interpretation are related to the mythic god Hermes, a messenger and mediator between gods and mortals, who crosses the thresholds and traverses the boundaries because he can ‘speak’ and understand both languages, the divine and the human, even if they appear utterly alien to each other.

Understanding the symbolic meanings embodied in the archetypal images of Tarot Arcana and bringing them to consciousness contributes to the re-symbolisation of the Self in the process of gradually removing the Ego from its privileged, egocentric position and enriching the human mind with other ways of knowing that complement its solely rational functions. The task of the reader is to make available the information concealed in the unconscious; thus to facilitate a process of individuation for the subject of the reading who is an equal participant in the emerging therapeutic and learning relation! For Jung, the *intuitive* function is non-rational (but not irrational), and the contents of intuition ‘have the character of being given in contrast to the “derived” or “deduced” character’ (Noddings & Shore, 1984, p.25) in a logical manner pertaining to two other, strictly rational, Jungian functions. For Hillman (1997, p. 45), it is the human soul that ‘selects the image I live’, and each image is what Plato called a *paradeigma* or pattern. When we look upon the patterns created by the Tarot pictures, we enter what Noddings and Shore (1984) call *an intuitive mode* of perception. Etymologically, intuition is derived from the Latin verb *intueri*, which means *to look upon*. In the Middle Ages, the word *intuition* was used ‘to describe an ineffable mystical experience of identification with God’ (Noddings & Shore, 1984, p.11). Tarot hermeneutic is a process of reading and interpreting these implicit patterns embodied in the images of the Arcana and as yet concealed by the unconscious; the readings that encompass an intuitive mode of perception reveal them, thereby making them explicit and integrated in consciousness. While the ‘fostering of intuition as an aid to learning and knowing was not on [Jung’s] agenda’ (Noddings & Shore, 1984, p.27) explicitly, it is the Tarot symbolism that triggers the stream of the unconscious and serves as a device to educate and strengthen the human intuitive function invaluable for meaning-making.

The split between theory and practice led, in modern times, to a spectator theory of knowledge and strict disciplinary boundaries between sciences and humanities. The detached gaze at the ‘spectacle’ of antiquity is, rather ironically, a precursor to modernity’s scientific method. Scientific, intellectually certain, knowledge as cognitive *episteme* became distinguished from, and opposed to, the creative arts as *techne* or τέχνη. Tarot pictures are artistic productions—*techne*; the pictures mastered by human skill inspired, in turn, by the creative imagination of the particular artist who designed a given deck. *Techne* is often translated as craftsmanship, handicraft or skill; the products of *techne* are artefacts, such as Tarot pictures. In its dimension as a *techne*, Tarot becomes a powerful, albeit alternative, educational aid in the context of post-formal holistic education and mental health alike. However, Tarot as *praxis* is equally if not more important. In Greek mythology, *Praxis* is also another name for Aphrodite, the goddess of love who was a

central character in the story of Eros and Psyche. The myth tells us that it is by virtue of active learning from novel life experiences imposed on her by Praxis (or Aphrodite), rather than by a theoretical contemplation of the objects of knowledge *already possessed* by the conscious mind, that Psyche, as a personification of *human* soul, was eventually able to reunite with Aphrodite's son, the *divine* Eros.

In Plato's *Symposium*, Diotima the Priestess teaches Socrates that Eros or Love is 'located' *in-between* lack and plenty; it is a spirit or daemon that, importantly, can hold two opposites together as a whole, therefore to eventually reconcile that which analytic thinking habitually perceives dualistically, that is, as binary *irreconcilable* opposites. Jung used the Latin term *coincidentia oppositorum* for the apparently mystical coincidence of opposites, such as psyche and matter, which takes place in synchronistic experiences. It was Hermes, the messenger of the gods, who finally summoned the human Psyche to Olympus where she reunited with her beloved, divine Eros, having been granted a godlike immortality in this loving union. It is through being driven by Eros/Love that Psyche was able to meet multiple challenges and overcome the obstacles created by Praxis. *And it is only through love and compassion for the often suffering human spirit that an expert Tarot reader can intuit, understand and narrate the subtle meanings encoded in the symbolism of the pictures, hence making each reading a precious learning experience.*

It is our learning from life experiences embodied in the symbolism of the pictures that not only leads to human development and eventual individuation but can also reconnect an individual *psyche* with its symbolic origin in *Anima Mundi*, the soul of the world, because our unconscious ideas are archetypal in nature and partake of the collective unconscious. Jung noticed that such conceptualisation

is particularly true of religious ideas, but the central concepts of science, philosophy, and ethics are no exception to this rule. In their present form they are variants of archetypal ideas created by consciously applying and adapting these ideas to reality. For it is the function of consciousness not only to recognise and assimilate the external world through the gateway of the senses, but to translate into visible reality the world within us (Jung CW 8. 342).

This is a prerogative of Tarot as an educational and counselling tool: to *translate into visible reality the deep and invisible, internal world within us* and to enrich human experience with deep spiritual meaning. As complemented by imagination and intuition, the interpretation of images, according to Jung, 'reflects a higher level of intellect and, by not forcibly representing the unknowable as known, gives a more faithful picture of the real state of affairs' (Jung CW 11. 417). Tarot images and symbols, when interpreted, create 'something that is ... in the process of formation. If we reduce this by analysis to something that is generally known, we destroy the true value of the symbol; but to attribute hermeneutic significance to it is consistent with its value and meaning' (Jung CW 7. 492). Each meaningful reading represents what Jean Watson (1985) called, in the area of nurse education, the occasions of caring. Noddings explains that the occasions of caring constitute the moments when nurse and patient, or teacher and student, meet and must decide what to do with the moment, what to share, which needs to express or whether to remain silent. This encounter 'needs to be a guiding spirit of what we do in education' (Noddings, 1991, p.168); such a guiding, relational and caring spirit is

ontologically preeminent in Tarot hermeneutic. As recently noted by philosopher Abbot Mark Patrick Hederman (2003, p. 86) in his remarkable book *Tarot: Talisman or Taboo? Reading the World as Symbol*, Tarot provides us with the symbolic system to fill the gaps produced 'where education and trained sensibility are in short supply'. Hederman insists that 'each of us should be given at least the rudiments of one of the most elusive and important symbolic systems if we are even to begin to understand human relationships. This would require tapping into a wavelength and a communication system other than the cerebral [that] covers the three Rs of traditional education' (2003, p. 87). I wholeheartedly share this urgent and noble task.

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